A FORCE TO RULE THE SKIES

WORLD-CLASS ACQUISITIONS HAVE GIVEN THE INDIAN AIR FORCE A COMBAT EDGE IN THE REGION. ROBUST IN DEFENCE, LETHAL IN STRIKE CAPABILITY, IT SERVES AS A WARNING TO OUR TWO ADVERSARIES

By Pradip R. Sagar





Heron



The Indian Air Force (IAF) opened a new chapter in its history in September when the first of the 56 C-295 medium-lift tactical transport aircraft was formally inducted. The first squadron of the C-295s will be based at Vadodara. Furthermore, while the first 16 aircraft will be assembled at the Airbus facility in Seville, Spain, the remaining 40 will be produced by a joint venture of Tata and Airbus in a manufacturing plant in Vadodara. This is the first time that a military aircraft will be manufactured in India by a private consortium. Each aircraft will have an indigenous electronic warfare system made by Bharat Electronics Ltd and Bharat Dynamics Ltd—a perfect blend of Western technology and Indian expertise. With its unique ability to take off and land from unprepared landing grounds, the IAF believes the C-295 will boost its capabilities to meet mission requirements in forward areas near the Line of Actual Control (LAC) with China. Indeed, the Rs 22,000 crore contract to buy C-295s is the latest instance of the IAF's acquisition of some of the world's most advanced platforms. Today, Rafale fighters, Chinook and Apache helicopters, S400 air defence systems, sophisticated missiles integrated with fighter jets and a host of radars have made the IAF one of the world's most lethal air forces.

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